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—Tacitus, *describing the Roman Empire.*

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The New Military Humanism

Noam Chomsky

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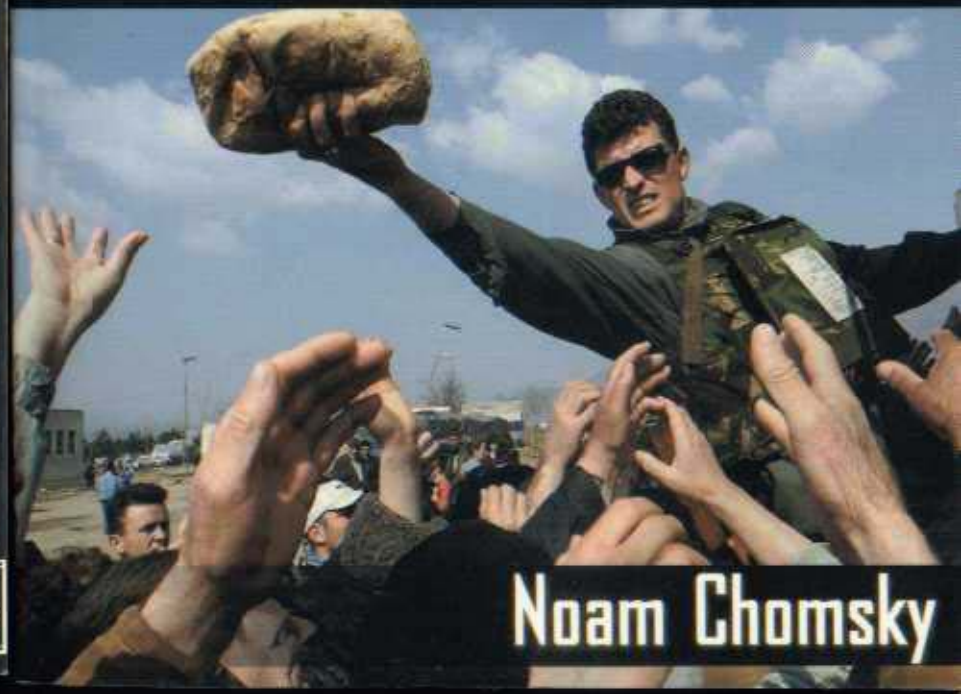
LESSONS FROM KOSOVO



Noam Chomsky

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CHAPTER 1

"In the Name of Principles and Values"*

The crisis in Kosovo has excited passion and visionary exaltation of a kind rarely witnessed. The events have been portrayed as "a landmark in international relations," opening the gates to a stage of world history with no precedent, a new epoch of moral rectitude under the guiding hand of an "idealistic New World bent on ending inhumanity."[1] This New Humanism, timed fortuitously with a new millennium, will displace the crass and narrow interest politics of a mean-spirited past. Novel conceptions of world order are being forged, interlaced with inspirational lessons about human affairs and global society. These new conceptions are to displace the decaying institutions of world order that have proven to be a "disastrous failure," hence must be discarded in favor of emerging ideas with "innovative but justifiable" departures from earlier norms. The utopianism of earlier generations may be fit only for ridicule, but the visions that are to take their place are genuine, and genuinely inspiring.

* Some of the material here has appeared in articles in the U.S. and elsewhere in 1999. For suggestions and assistance, I would like to express particular thanks to Sanjoy Mahajan, David Peterson, and Knut Rognes.

If the picture is true, if it has even a particle of truth, then remarkable prospects lie before us. Material and intellectual resources surely are at hand to overcome terrible tragedies at little cost, with only a modicum of good will. It takes little imagination or knowledge to compile a wish list of tasks to be undertaken that should confer enormous benefits on suffering people. In particular, crimes of the nature and scale of Kosovo are all too easily found, and many could be overcome, at least significantly alleviated, with a fraction of the effort and zeal expended in the cause that has consumed the Western powers and their intellectual cultures in early 1999.

For many good reasons, then, we should seek to locate and identify such tasks and problems and to place them in the forefront of attention and concern. If the high-minded spirit of the liberation of Kosovo has even shreds of authenticity, if at last leaders are acting "in the name of principles and values" that are truly humane as confidently proclaimed (Vaclav Havel), then there will be exciting opportunities to place critically important issues on the agenda of practical and immediate action. And even if reality turns out to fall short of the flattering self-portrait, the effort still has the merit of directing attention to what should be undertaken by those who regard the fine words as something more than cynical opportunism.

Let us try, then, to review and understand what has happened, how and why it is portrayed in the manner we have seen, and what new ventures can be undertaken, with ease, by application of the "universal principles and values espoused by European Union and NATO leaders" and by the commentators who applaud them. Since the range is too vast to sample seriously, let us keep to cases that are similar in essential respects to the tragedy that aroused such intense emotion and commitment in the early months of 1999. Apart from offering a fair test of the New Humanism on its own chosen terrain, such cases are of intrinsic significance and value, at least by elementary moral standards.

To avoid misunderstanding, my aim here is not to contribute to the debate about what should be, or should have been, done in Kosovo, except tangentially. Rather, it is to examine the framework in which events proceeded on their course, with its terrible human

toll; and to consider the likely implications of what took place, and of its portrayal and interpretation. That requires an almost wrenching shift from the single-minded concentration of the past months on a corner of the deeply troubled Balkans, which has displaced to the margins other concerns of no little weight. For the reasons just indicated the shift will be limited here to a narrow category of similar tasks and problems, but should properly be extended far beyond.

On March 24, U.S.-led NATO forces launched cruise missiles and bombs at targets throughout the Federal Republic of Yugoslavia (FRY),[2] "plunging America into a military conflict that President Clinton said was necessary to stop ethnic cleansing and bring stability to Eastern Europe," lead stories in the press reported. By bombing the FRY, Clinton informed the nation, "we are upholding our values, protecting our interests, and advancing the cause of peace." "We cannot respond to such tragedies everywhere, but when ethnic conflict turns into ethnic cleansing where we can make a difference, we must try, and that is clearly the case in Kosovo." "Had we faltered" in what the heading of his speech calls "A Just and Necessary War," "the result would have been a moral and strategic disaster. The Albanian Kosovars would have become a people without a homeland, living in difficult conditions in some of the poorest countries in Europe…," a fate that the U.S. cannot tolerate for suffering people. Secretary of State Madeleine Albright had already sounded the alarm, declaring on February 1 "that this kind of thing cannot stand, that you cannot in 1999 have this kind of barbaric ethnic cleansing. It is ultimately better that democracies stand up against this kind of evil."[3]

Clinton's European allies agreed. Under the heading "A New Generation Draws the Line," British Prime Minister Tony Blair declared that this is a new kind of war in which we are fighting "for values," for "a new internationalism where the brutal repression of whole ethnic groups will no longer be tolerated," "for a world where those responsible for such crimes have nowhere to hide." "We are fighting for a world where dictators are no longer able to visit horrific punishments on their own peoples in order to stay in power." We are entering "a new millennium where dictators know that they cannot get away with ethnic cleansing or repress their peoples with

impunity." German Foreign Minister Joschka Fischer "became an advocate of what Ulrich Beck, a German intellectual, has called 'NATO's new military humanism'—the notion, defended by Secretary of State Madeleine K. Albright, that the defense of human rights is a form of mission."[4]

"The New Interventionism" was hailed by intellectual opinion and legal scholars who proclaimed a new era in world affairs in which the "enlightened states" will at last be able to use force where they "believe it to be just," discarding "the restrictive old rules" and obeying "modern notions of justice" that they fashion. "The crisis in Kosovo illustrates...America's new willingness to do what it thinks right—international law notwithstanding."[5] Now freed from the shackles of the Cold War and old-fashioned constraints of world order, the enlightened states can dedicate themselves with full vigor to the mission of upholding human rights and bringing justice and freedom to suffering people everywhere, by force if necessary.

The enlightened states are the United States and its British associate, perhaps also others who enlist in their crusades for justice and human rights. Their mission is resisted only by "the defiant, the indolent, and the miscreant," the "disorderly" elements of the world.[6] The rank of enlightenment is apparently conferred by definition. One will search in vain for credible attempts to provide evidence or argument for the critical distinction between enlightened and disorderly, surely not from history. The history is in any event deemed irrelevant by the familiar doctrine of "change of course," which holds that, Yes, in the past we have erred out of naiveté or faulty information, but now we are returning to the traditional path of righteousness. Examination of the record is nothing more than "sound-bites and invectives about Washington's historically evil foreign policy," hence "easy to ignore," we are instructed by one of the most prominent scholar/advocates of the "emerging norms."[7] There is, accordingly, no purpose in asking what might be learned from old, musty stories about the past, even though the decision-making structure and its institutional base remain intact and unchanged.

On June 3, NATO and Serbia reached a Peace Accord. The U.S. triumphantly declared victory, having successfully concluded its "10-week struggle to compel Mr. Milosevic to say uncle." Victory, though not yet peace: the iron fist remains poised until the victors determine that their interpretation of the Peace Accord has been imposed. A broad consensus was articulated by *New York Times* global analyst Thomas Friedman: "From the start the Kosovo problem has been about how we should react when bad things happen in unimportant places." The enlightened states have opened a new millennium by providing an answer to this critical question of the modern era, pursuing the moral principle that "once the refugee evictions began, ignoring Kosovo would be wrong...and therefore using a huge air war for a limited objective was the only thing that made sense."[8]

Inspection of the timing alone shows that this common refrain can hardly be accurate: uncontroversially, the "huge air war" was undertaken before "the refugee evictions began" at a new level, and led to a rapid and vast escalation of evictions and other atrocities, facts reported extensively in Friedman's own journal and others. That much at least is generally recognized. It can be denied only by assuming a determined stance of "intentional ignorance," to borrow the phrase coined by the advocate of the "new internationalism" just quoted, in an incisive report he co-authored on atrocities of U.S. mercenary forces and the State Department reaction to them.[9]

The stance of intentional ignorance has ample precedent. A classic account was given by George Orwell in his preface to *Animal Farm*, which he devoted to the ways in which in free societies "Unpopular ideas can be silenced, and inconvenient facts kept dark, without any need for any official ban." This "sinister" form of "literary censorship" is "largely voluntary," Orwell observed. In part it derives from a good education, which instills the "general tacit agreement that 'it wouldn't do' to mention that particular fact." As a consequence of such intentional ignorance and other factors, "Anyone who challenges the prevailing orthodoxy finds himself silenced with surprising effectiveness." *Animal Farm* is perhaps Orwell's most famous book, the preface one of his least known essays. It remained unpublished, and was discovered

only thirty years later, then prominently published, only to return to general oblivion.[1]

While Friedman's own (and conventional) answer to his rhetorical question is untenable, a credible answer appears in the same journal on the same day, though only obliquely. Reporting from Ankara, correspondent Stephen Kinzer writes that "Turkey's best-known human rights advocate [Akin Birdal] entered prison" to serve his sentence for having "urged the state to reach a peaceful settlement with Kurdish rebels."[2] Looking beyond the sporadic and generally uninformative or misleading news reports and commentary, we discover that the sentencing of the courageous president of the Human Rights Association of Turkey is only one episode of a campaign of intimidation and harassment of human rights advocates who are investigating and reporting horrendous atrocities and calling for peaceful resolution of a conflict that has been marked by one of the most savage campaigns of ethnic cleansing and state terror of the 1990s. The campaign has proceeded with mounting fury thanks to the active participation of the leader of the enlightened states, "upholding our values, protecting our interests, and advancing the cause of peace" (in the President's words) in a way that is all too familiar to those who do not prefer intentional ignorance.

We return to details, merely noting here that these events of the 1990s, continuing right now and taking place within NATO and under European jurisdiction, provide a rather striking illustration—far from the only one—of the answer given by the enlightened states to the question of "how we should react when bad things happen in unimportant places": We should react by helping to *escalate the atrocities*, a mission accomplished in Kosovo as well. Such elements of the real world of today raise some rather serious questions about the New Humanism, even if we adopt the doctrine of "change of course" and agree to efface history and its lessons about the institutions of power that reign virtually unchallenged, free to do what they "think right."

By chance, the credible answer to Friedman's question was confirmed, and the contours of the New Humanism clearly delineated, by the second of the two major national journals, the *Washington Post*, in paired editorials at the war's end. One is entitled "Kosovo's

Bumpy Road," the other, "Turkey's Kurdish Opening." The first offers advice to NATO, the second expresses the "hopes" of "friends of Turkey."[3]

In the case of Kosovo, Washington should "show no sympathy" for the villains responsible for savage ethnic cleansing and other atrocities conducted under NATO's bombs. On the contrary, "NATO should intensify its bombing" if it detects any sign of "recalcitrance" in living up to principles that "can't be compromised." Primary among these is the principle that the international peacekeeping force mandated by the U.N. Security Council must have "a NATO general at its command—not an official of the United Nations, the European Union, the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe [OSCE] or anybody else."[4] In other words, NATO must firmly reject the Security Council Resolution it had just initiated and signed, which called for an "international security presence" deployed "under U.N. auspices," "with substantial NATO participation" (and no further mention of NATO). And any "recalcitrance" in submitting to NATO's unilateral decisions should be met with renewed violence by the stern disciplinarian.

In the case of Turkey, the story is different. Washington should most definitely "show sympathy" for the villains responsible for savage ethnic cleansing and other atrocities against the Kurds, surely comparable to Serbian crimes in Kosovo and not carried out under NATO's bombs. Not a very surprising conclusion, since Washington occupies a prominent place among the villains. In the case of Turkey and the Kurds, it is the "captive leader of the Kurdish separatist movement," Abdullah Ocalan, who is "widely held responsible for the death of thousands [more accurately, tens of thousands] in the Kurds' war with the Turks." The term "widely held" excludes the leading international human rights organizations and independent scholarship but includes Ankara and Washington. Similarly, and with comparable merit, in Belgrade and perhaps Moscow it is the guerrilla forces of the Albanian separatist movement that are "widely held responsible" for death of thousands in the Albanians' war with the Serbs in the period before the NATO bombing, of course the relevant period for an assessment of

the decision to bomb. There were indeed atrocities during this period; we return to Washington's account of them. No serious analyst regards them as remotely comparable to the atrocities carried out by "the NATO-oriented Turkish armed forces"—the editors' term for the Turkish military forces armed and trained by Washington, with an increasing flow of arms as atrocities mounted and the Clinton Administration was bent on demonstrating "America's new willingness to do what it thinks right."

The editors issue no call for bombing Ankara or Washington. Rather, "friends of Turkey must hope it can muster the courage to broaden its perspective and to conduct an honest exploration of the Ocalan initiative" for a peaceful settlement, referring to the peace initiative of the "captive leader" that has been rejected for seven years by the Turkish government and its friends in Washington, and still is, as "Turkey's best-known human rights advocate" had learned just days before. If Turkey chooses "to treat its national cancer, the problem of the aggrieved Kurdish minority," the editors continue, then it will no longer be "at odds with the humane democratic values of the Western nations whose company it values," notably the humane values of the nation that provides Turkey with a huge flow of lethal weapons "to treat its national cancer" in the manner Washington prefers. "For the Turks, accommodating the Kurds won't be easy," the editors recognize. Kurds now ask for the "cultural and linguistic rights" that have been denied them (unlike Kosovo), but later "some of them" may go on to ask "for autonomy and self-determination" (like the Kosovo Albanians for many years). Hence Turkey's leaders merit sympathetic understanding from their friends in Washington.

A fuller account, to which we briefly return, draws the contrast even more sharply between state terror conducted with the approval and avid support of the enlightened states, most prominently their leader, and state terror that is villainous and must be severely punished because it conflicts with their demands. There are no novelties here. Merely to give a single example, a few years earlier the editors of the same journal were advising their government on more effective means to "fit Nicaragua back into a Central American mode" and impose "reasonable conduct by a regional

standard" —that is, to fit Nicaragua into the mode of the murderous terror states backed by Washington, and to adopt their "regional standard" of vicious atrocities that vastly exceeded any crimes attributed to the Nicaraguan enemy, apart from the crime of disobedience to the ruler of the hemisphere.[4]

The stance is in fact conventional, not only among the leaders of the enlightened states but also among their enemies and predecessors. *Pravda* in the old days made similar distinctions, again with comparable merit. The historical record should be familiar.

These are among the most important questions raised by the Balkans war of 1999. They remain out of sight—within the "enlightened states," at least. Elsewhere, they are readily perceived, over a broad spectrum. To select several remote points for illustration, a prominent Israeli commentator on military and strategic affairs sees the enlightened states as "a danger to the world." He describes their "new rules of the game" as a reversion to the colonial era, with the resort to force "cloaked in moralistic righteousness" as the rich and powerful do "what seems to them to be justified." Another commentator, head of the Center Party and wife of the ex-Chief of Staff, writes that "power won and peace lost": "the rules of the game are far from having been changed…In this story there are no good and evil, only very evil and less evil." At a very different point on the spectrum, Alexander Solzhenitsyn, a Western idol when he is saying the right things, offers a succinct definition of the New Humanism: "The aggressors have kicked aside the U.N., opening a new era where might is right." To take a last example, Vuk Draskovic, deposed by Milosevic for opposing his war policy and calling for peace protests, received high praise in the West as the Good Serb, the voice of reason and independence in the government and the hope for Serbian democracy in a post-Milosevic era. His opposition was based on Solzhenitsyn's thesis: "we must recognize the fact that the world today is often ruled by the rule of power, and not the rule of law. We must be very brave and approach compromise."[5]

We return to a broader sample, representing a good part of the world's population, perhaps a majority, one respected hawkish policy analyst alleges. They might agree with an observation by the prominent and influential—though little celebrated—radical pacifist A.J. Muste:

> The problem after a war is with the victor. He thinks he has just proved that war and violence pay. Who will now teach him a lesson?[8]

"There should be no indulging in illusions about [NATO] aiming at defending Kosovars," Solzhenitsyn added: "if the protection of the oppressed was their real concern, they could have been defending for example the miserable Kurds, who have been torn by different countries for about 40 or 50 years, and are subject to extermination"—an exaggeration, but hardly worse than the extreme forms of Holocaust revisionism that compare the horrendous Serb atrocities that followed the bombing to Hitler's genocidal policies, a comparison that would cut a wide swath were it taken seriously. NATO tolerates Turkey's ethnic cleansing and terror because it is their "paying ally," Solzhenitsyn adds, confirming the judgment in the West about the "goodwill Turkey has built up over its actions in the Kosovo crisis" as it pays its dues once again, this time joining in the "moralistic righteousness" of the rich and powerful over Turkish-style atrocities.[9]

The conjunction elicits no notice, a fact that might interest people genuinely concerned about the moral and intellectual culture of the enlightened states.

The larger issues highlighted by the most recent of the wars of Yugoslav secession came into focus with the fading of the Cold War. Central among these is the claimed right of intervention on the part of states or alliances on humanitarian grounds, which extends the scope of legitimate use of force. There is general agreement on the timing, but the conclusions about "humanitarian intervention" are phrased in different ways, reflecting the evaluation of the intent and likely consequences of the "emerging norms of justified intervention."[10]

The enlarged options are of two kinds: those carried out under United Nations auspices and in conformity with the U.N. Charter, which is agreed to be the foundation of international law in the post-World War II period; and those carried out unilaterally, with no Security Council authorization, by states or alliances (the U.S. or NATO for example, or the Warsaw Pact in earlier years). If sufficiently powerful, arrogant, and internally well-disciplined, such

alliances may designate themselves "the international community" (standard practice in the U.S. and often NATO generally). Questions arise about the first category, but that is not our topic here. Rather, we are concerned with the "emerging norms of justified intervention" by states or alliances that do not seek or are not granted authorization from the international community, but that use force because "they believe it to be just." In practice, that reduces to "America's new willingness to do what it thinks right," apart from operations in "unimportant countries" of no concern to the reigning global superpower (for example, peacekeeping interventions of the West African states, which received retroactive authorization from the United Nations).

From one perspective, the extended scope of intervention has always been legitimate, indeed meritorious, but was obstructed during the Cold War because "the defiant, the indolent, and the miscreant" who resist the mission were then able to rely for support on the Communist powers, dedicated to subversion and insurrection as they sought to conquer the world.[11] With the Cold War over, the "disorderly" can no longer impede the good works of the enlightened states, and the New Humanism can therefore flourish under their wise and just leadership.

From a contrasting perspective, "the new interventionism" is replaying an old record. It is an updated variant of traditional practices that were impeded in a bipolar world system that allowed some space for nonalignment—a concept that effectively vanishes when one of the two poles disappears.[12] The Soviet Union, and to some extent China, set limits on the actions of the Western powers in their traditional domains, not only by virtue of the military deterrent, but also because of their occasional willingness, however opportunistic, to lend support to targets of Western subversion and aggression (in practice, overwhelmingly U.S.-based, for obvious reasons of power). With the Soviet deterrent in decline, the Cold War victors are more free to exercise their will under the cloak of good intentions but in pursuit of interests that have a very familiar ring outside the realm of enlightenment.

The self-described bearers of enlightenment happen to be the rich and powerful, the inheritors of the colonial and neocolonial

systems of global dominion: they are the North, the First World. The disorderly miscreants who defy them have been at the other end of the stick: they are the South, the Third World—the "developing" or "less developed countries" or "transitional economies," all notions with a heavy ideological overlay. The division is not sharp and clear; nothing is in the domain of human affairs. But the tendencies are hard to miss, and they suggest some reasons for the difference of perspective in interpretation of "the emerging norms of justified intervention."

The conflict of interpretation is difficult to resolve if history is declared irrelevant and the present scene is glimpsed only through the filters established by the enlightened states, which transmit the evil deeds of official enemies while blocking unwanted images: to take the most obvious current illustration, atrocities pass through unhindered, even magnified, if they are attributable to Belgrade, but not if they trace back to Ankara/Washington. As long as these restrictions on inquiry are observed, the preferred interpretation has at least a chance to survive inspection.

The general questions will be deferred to the end (chapters 6 and 7), but they lie in the not very distant background of the consideration of particular humanitarian crises: Kosovo Albanians, Kurds of Turkey, and others. If we hope to understand anything about the world, in such particular cases we should ask why decisions on forceful intervention are made one way or another by the states with the power to exercise their judgment and will. The questions were raised at the outset of the recent revival of the thesis that the enlightened states should use force when they "believe it to be just"—"revival" is the right term, because of its well-known and distinguished origins. In the 1993 American Academy Conference on Emerging Norms, one of the most distinguished figures in the academic discipline of international relations, Ernest Haas, raised a simple and cogent question, which has since received a clear and instructive answer. He observed that NATO was then intervening in Iraq and Bosnia to protect Kurds and Muslims, and asked: "will NATO take the same interventionist view if and when Turkey begins to lean more heavily on its Kurdish insurgents?" The question poses a clear test of the New Humanism: Is it guided by

power interests, or by humanitarian concern? Is the resort to force undertaken "in the name of principles and values," as professed? Or are we witnessing something more crass and familiar?

The test was a good one, and the answer was not long in coming. As Haas raised the question, Turkey was leaning much more heavily on the Kurdish population of the Southeast while rejecting offers of peaceful settlement that would permit cultural and linguistic rights. Very shortly the operation escalated to extremes of ethnic cleansing and state terror. NATO took a very definite "interventionist view," in particular NATO's leader, which intervened decisively to escalate the atrocities. The ideological institutions adapted in the manner just illustrated, also following a familiar path.

The implications concerning the larger issues seem rather clear, particularly when we compare this "interventionist view" to the one adopted for the Kosovo crisis, a lesser one on moral grounds, not only for reasons of scale (crucially and dramatically, prior to the decision to bombard the FRY) but also because it is outside the bounds and jurisdiction of the NATO powers and their institutions, unlike Turkey, which is squarely within. The two cases differ sharply on a different dimension, however: Serbia is one of those disorderly miscreants that impede the institution of the U.S.-dominated global system, while Turkey is a loyal client state that contributes substantially to this project. Again, the factors that drive policy do not seem hard to discern, and the "North-South" divisions over the larger issues and their interpretation seem to fall into place as well.

The leading issues that arise are not resolved by a single example, and this one case itself requires careful elaboration and inquiry. The natural conclusions have a prima facie plausibility, however. When we look more closely we find, I think, that these conclusions come through loud and clear. We also find that they are reinforced by a broad range of considerations that reach well beyond military intervention, including international financial arrangements, trade agreements, control over technology and material and human resources, and the whole array of devices by which power is con-

centrated and organized, and applied to institute systems of domination and control.

These are the kinds of questions that should be in the immediate background as we turn to the "unimportant places" of elite perception, ask what is happening there and why, and most importantly, why power systems make the choices they do and what we should be doing about those choices.

The New Humanism was given forceful expression in the Clinton Doctrine, outlined by National Security Advisor Anthony Lake, the Administration's leading intellectual: "Throughout the Cold War we contained a global threat to market democracies," but now we can move on to "consolidate the victory of democracy and open markets." Press commentators had already recognized that "with the end of the cold war...interventionism has won out"; the issue that remains is whether policy will be guided by Bush-style balance of power realism or the Clinton-Lake "'new-Wilsonian' view in which the United States uses its monopoly on power to intervene in other countries to promote democracy."[2]

Several years of Clinton's "new-Wilsonianism" convinced observers that American foreign policy had entered a "noble phase" with a "saintly glow," though more sober voices warned that by "granting idealism a near exclusive hold on our foreign policy" we might neglect our own interests in the service of others. It is between these poles that serious discussion largely proceeds.[3]

Though the new era opened with the fall of the Berlin Wall in November 1989 according to the logic of the doctrine, it is only a decade later, with the NATO intervention to protect Kosovo Albanians from brutal ethnic cleansing, that its contours have been firmly established. The NATO bombings are therefore a defining moment in world affairs, the first time in history when the "saintly glow" of policy shines through for all to see—"evidently" and "obviously," respected voices announce.[4] It is symbolically appropriate that this remarkable new era should break forth at the opening of the third millennium of the Christian era, perhaps to be the theme of inspiring rhetoric as the day approaches.

Even skeptics agreed, long before Kosovo, that "clearly, something important is going on."[5] That much is surely true, and the flood of impassioned rhetoric accompanying the NATO intervention of 1999 underscores its importance.

Any attempt to address the topic should distinguish clearly between two questions: (1) what should be done, and (2) what is being done and why. The answers to question (2) bear on the choice of action, but do not determine it. It is easy to find historical examples in which actions undertaken on cynical grounds, or worse, had beneficial consequences that were plausibly anticipated, so it might have been appropriate to support such actions whatever the motives and goals. It is more difficult to find examples of state actions undertaken on humanitarian grounds, but insofar as such exist, they might have (anticipated) beneficial or harmful consequences. Though the merest truisms, these distinctions should be kept in mind in the present case as in all others.

Question (2) is of particular importance when it is elevated to extraordinary heights, as in the contemporary rhetoric of political leaders and commentators with regard to the New Humanism and its exemplification in NATO's Balkan intervention. It is that question that will concern me here. We can expect with some confidence that cases of the kind discussed will continue to arise. Valuable lessons can be learned by examining question (2) against the background of the broader range of questions raised by the New Humanism of the new millennium.

Even a cursory examination shows that the proclamations of the New Humanism are at best highly dubious. The narrowest focus, on the NATO intervention in Kosovo alone, suffices to undermine the lofty pronouncements. A broader look at the contemporary world powerfully reinforces the conclusion, and brings forth with stark clarity "the values" that are actually being upheld. If we deviate further from the marching orders that issue from Washington and London and allow the past to enter the discussion, we quickly discover that the "New Generation" is the old generation, and that the "new internationalism" replays old and unpleasant records. The actions of distinguished forebears, as well as the justifications offered and their merits, should also give us pause. High level planning for the new millennium, at least some of which is available to

those who choose to know, adds further warnings for people who really are committed to the values that are proclaimed.

The British press reported that Britain's phase of the NATO bombing was to be called "Operation Agricola."[23] If so, the choice is apt, and a tribute to Britain's classical education. Apart from being a major criminal who helped cure the country's Celtic infection, Agricola was the father-in-law of Tacitus, noted for his observation that "crime once exposed had no refuge but in audacity," and for his famous description of the Roman empire: "Brigands of the world, they create a desolation and call it peace."

Let us begin by keeping to the rules and focusing attention on the designated case: Serb atrocities in Kosovo, which are quite real, and often ghastly. We immediately discover that the bombing was not undertaken in "response" to ethnic cleansing and to "reverse" it, as leaders alleged.[24] With full awareness of the likely consequences, Clinton and Blair decided in favor of a war that led to a radical escalation of ethnic cleansing along with other deleterious effects.

In the year before the bombing, according to NATO sources, about 2000 people had been killed in Kosovo and several hundred thousand had become internal refugees. The humanitarian catastrophe was overwhelmingly attributable to Yugoslav police and military forces, the main victims being ethnic Albanians, commonly assumed to constitute about 90% of the population by the 1990s.

Prior to the bombing, and for two days following its onset, the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) reported no data on refugees, though many Kosovars—Albanian and Serb—had been leaving the province for years, and entering as well, sometimes as a direct consequence of the Balkan wars, sometimes for economic and other reasons.[25] After three days of bombing, UNHCR reported on March 27 that 4000 had fled Kosovo to Albania and Macedonia, the two neighboring countries. Until April 1 the UNHCR provided no daily figures on refugees, according to the *New York Times*. By April 5, the *Times* reported that "more than 350,000 have left Kosovo since March 24," relying on UNHCR figures, while unknown numbers of Serbs fled north to Serbia to escape the increased violence from the air and on the

ground. After the war, it was reported that half the Serb population had "moved out when the NATO bombing began." There have been varying estimates of the number of refugees within Kosovo before the NATO bombing. Cambridge University Law Professor Marc Weller, Legal Advisor to the Kosova (Kosovo Albanian) Delegation at the 1999 Rambouillet Conference on Kosovo, reports that after the withdrawal of the international monitors (KVM, Kosovo Verification Mission) on March 19, 1999, "within a few days the number of displaced had again risen to over 200,000." Basing himself on U.S. intelligence, House Intelligence Committee Chair Porter Goss gave the estimate of 250,000 internally displaced. The UNHCR reported on March 11 that "more than 230,000 people remain displaced within Kosovo."[26]

By the time of the peace accord of June 3, the UNHCR reported 671,500 refugees beyond the borders of the FRY, in addition to 70,000 in Montenegro and 75,000 who went to other countries.[27] To these we may add the unknown numbers displaced within Kosovo, perhaps some 2–300,000 in the year before the bombing, far more afterwards, with varying estimates; and according to the Yugoslav Red Cross, over a million displaced within Serbia after the bombing,[28] along with many who left Serbia.

The numbers reported from Kosovo are, unfortunately, all too familiar. To mention only two cases that are prime illustrations of "our values" in the 1990s, the refugee toll prior to the NATO bombing is similar to the State Department estimate for Colombia in the same year (we return to this instructive comparison); and the UNHCR totals at the war's end are about the same as the number of Palestinians who fled or were expelled in 1948, another policy issue that is very much alive today. In that case, refugees numbered about 750,000, 85% of the population, with over 400 villages levelled, and ample violence. The comparison was not overlooked in the Israeli press, which described Kosovo as Palestine 1948 with TV cameras (Gideon Levi). Foreign Minister Ariel Sharon warned that if "NATO's aggression" is "legitimized," the next step might be a call for autonomy and links to the Palestinian Authority for Galilee—the "underpopulated Galilee" (Irving Howe), meaning that it has too few Jews and too many Arabs. Others comment that

"the Serbs could almost have studied Israeli tactics in 1948 in their village destruction campaign, except of course the Palestinians had no NATO to back them up" (Ian Williams, a fervent supporter of the NATO bombing).[26]

To be sure, the Palestinians could appeal to a U.N. Resolution that guaranteed them the right of return or, if they refused, compensation: U.N. 194 of Dec. 11, 1948, which spelled out the intended meaning of Article 13(2) of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UD), adopted the preceding day. But such guarantees depend on the will of the superpowers, primarily the United States, which regarded the U.N. Resolution as a mere formality. Meanwhile Article 13(2) became perhaps the best-known Article of the UD as it was converted into an ideological weapon against the Soviet enemy for violating it by refusing to allow Jews to leave, a weapon wielded with great indignation, passion, and "moralistic righteousness," and always with omission of the final words guaranteeing the right to return to one's own country, a display of audacity that might have impressed Tacitus, and that proceeded annually without a false note or raised eyebrow, an interesting illustration of Orwell's maxim. Nonetheless, support for Article 13(2) remained official policy until it was rescinded by President Clinton, who formalized his stand that unworthy victims should "become a people without a homeland, living in difficult conditions in some of the poorest countries" in the world, far poorer than those of Europe.[27]

Clinton's formal renunciation of Article 13 of the UD received the usual notice— zero—which is fitting: U.S. isolation in the United Nations is so routine as perhaps not to merit report. And when the world is out of step, as it so commonly is, its position can be disregarded. Thus today, reporting on violence in Lebanon that is traced to the miserable conditions of Palestinians living there in hopeless exile, the *New York Times* can report that "The authorities [in Lebanon] have always insisted that...the Palestinians must be allowed to return to the lands they fled in 1948." So the authorities in Lebanon have, though it would be more informative to point out that Israel and the U.S. (since Clinton) are alone in rejecting Resolution 194 and the Article of the UD that it spells out. Adopting the same mode of shaping history, the report goes on to

describe how "cross-border attacks on Israel by Palestinian militias prompted the Israeli invasion of 1982," a conventional U.S. rendition of the fact that cross-border attacks had long ceased apart from the murderous attacks in the other direction, as Israel desperately sought to elicit some terrorist actions that could serve as a pretext for its planned U.S.-backed invasion. One can hardly accuse the reporter of deceit, however: that has long been the official line in the U.S.—though not in Israel, where the truth has been openly and publicly recognized from the first days of its invasion of Lebanon in 1982.[28]

Such examples, which are legion, should not be stored in dusty cabinets but rather placed on the front shelf, in plain view, as we watch the next chapters of history unfold.

The distinction between worthy and unworthy victims is traditional, as is its basis, remote from any moral principle apart from the rights demanded by power and privilege. Documentation on the matter is rich and compelling, but excluded from polite company by Orwell's maxim.[29]

As noted, Clinton's opposition to the right of return for victims of large scale ethnic cleansing left Washington in its familiar position of isolation in the international community, and in the equally familiar position of simultaneously rejecting the principles of the UD (for unworthy victims, Palestinians and many others) and passionately upholding them (for worthy victims, now Kosovo Albanians). Though readily understood in terms of power interests, the distinctions, when noticed at all, are portrayed as "double standards" or "mistakes" in respectable commentary. Attention to the facts reveals that there is a single standard, the one that great powers typically observe, and that although plans may go awry (aggressors have been defeated, etc.), the "mistakes" are overwhelmingly tactical.

The worthy/unworthy categories are often identified in complex and shifting ways. Thus Saddam Hussein was a friend and ally and proper recipient of substantial military and other aid from the U.S./U.K. (and other enlightened states) while he was only gassing Kurds, torturing dissidents, and otherwise committing the worst crimes of his career. But he instantly became a reincarnation of

Attila the Hun when he disobeyed orders in August 1990, then regaining his favored status after the Gulf war, in March 1991, when he was tacitly authorized by the U.S. to conduct the murderous suppression of a Shi'ite uprising in the South and a Kurdish uprising in the North (Washington's support was justified in order to preserve "stability," commentators thoughtfully intoned). He reverted to devil as policy shifted to destruction of Iraqi society while strengthening its dictator. Such policy shifts, which are common, require considerable agility on the part of those committed to Orwell's maxim.[7]

Continuing with Kosovo, refugees reported that immediately after the bombing began, the terror reached the capital city of Pristina, mostly spared before, and provided credible accounts of large-scale destruction of villages, brutal atrocities, and a radical increase in generation of refugees, perhaps an effort to expel the Albanian population. Similar reports, generally quite credible, were prominently featured throughout the media and journals, in extensive and often horrifying detail, the usual practice in the case of worthy victims under attack by official enemies.

One index of the effects of "the huge air war" was offered by Robert Hayden, director of the Center for Russian and East European Studies of the University of Pittsburgh: "the casualties among Serb civilians in the first three weeks of the war are higher than all of the casualties on both sides in Kosovo in the three months that led up to this war, and yet those three months were supposed to be a humanitarian catastrophe."[8] Admittedly, casualties among Serb civilians amount to little in the context of the jingoist hysteria that was whipped up for a war against Serbs. But the toll among Albanians in the first three weeks, estimated at the time in the hundreds though presumably much higher, was surely far beyond that of the preceding three months and probably the preceding years.

On March 27, U.S.-NATO Commanding General Wesley Clark announced that it was "entirely predictable" that Serb terror and violence would intensify after the NATO bombing. On the same day, State Department spokesperson James Rubin said that "The United States is extremely alarmed by reports of an escalating pattern of Serbian attacks on Kosovar Albanian civilians," now attributed in large part to paramilitary forces. Shortly after, Clark reported again that he was not surprised by the sharp escalation of Serb terror after the bombing: "The military authorities fully anticipated the vicious approach that Milosevic would adopt, as well as the terrible efficiency with which he would carry it out."[9]

General Clark's phrase "entirely predictable" is an overstatement. Nothing in human affairs is "entirely predictable," surely not the effects of extreme violence. But what happened at once was highly likely. As observed by Carnes Lord of the Fletcher School of Law and Diplomacy, formerly a Bush Administration national security advisor, "enemies often react when shot at," and "though Western officials continue to deny it, there can be little doubt that the bombing campaign has provided both motive and opportunity for a wider and more savage Serbian operation than what was first envisioned"[10]—by some, at least, if not the Commanding General.

The outcome was not unanticipated in Washington. On March 5, Italian Prime Minister Massimo D'Alema visited Washington, warning Clinton that if Milosevic did not capitulate immediately, "the result...would be 300,000 to 400,000 refugees passing into Albania"—and, he feared, Italy. Clinton turned to National Security Advisor Sandy Berger, who told D'Alema that in that case "NATO will keep bombing," with still more horrific results. House Intelligence Committee Chair Porter Goss informed the media that "Our intelligence community warned us months and days before [the bombing] that we would have a virtual explosion of refugees over the 250,000 that was expected as of last year [pre-bombing], that the Serb resolve would increase, that the conflict would spread, and that there would be ethnic cleansing." As far back as 1992, European monitors in Macedonia had "predicted a sudden, massive influx of ethnic Albanian refugees if hostilities spread into Kosovo."[11]

The reasons for these expectations are clear enough: people "react when shot at"—not by garlanding the attackers with flowers, and not where the attacker is strong, but where they are strong: in this case, on the ground, not by sending jet planes to bomb Washington and London. It takes no particular genius to reach

these conclusions, not access to secret intelligence. The overt NATO threat of direct invasion made the brutal reaction even more likely, again for reasons that could hardly have escaped Clinton, Blair, their associates, and commentators. One may recall how the U.S. reacted during World War II when it was never under the remotest threat of Japanese attack—and in fact, had not been under any threat since the war of 1812.

The threat of bombing presumably had already led to an increase in atrocities, though evidence is slight. The withdrawal of U.S.-led KVM on March 19 in preparation for the bombing presumably had the same consequence, again predictably. "The monitors were widely seen as the only remaining brake on Yugoslav troops," the *Washington Post* observed in a retrospective account; and releasing the brake, it must have been assumed, would lead to disaster. Other accounts agree. A subsequent detailed retrospective in the *New York Times* concludes that "The Serbs began attacking Kosovo Liberation Army strongholds on March 19, but their attack kicked into high gear on March 24, the night NATO began bombing Yugoslavia."* It would take a heavy dose of "intentional ignorance" to interpret the facts as mere coincidence.

Serbia officially opposed the withdrawal of the monitors. In a March 23 Resolution responding to the NATO Rambouillet ultimatum, the Serb National Assembly declared: "We also condemn the withdrawal of the OSCE Kosovo Verification Mission. There is not a single reason for this but to put the withdrawal into the service of blackmail and threats to our country."* The National Assembly Resolution was not reported by the mainstream media, which also did not publish the terms of the Rambouillet Agreement, though the latter was identified throughout the war as right and just. It was "the peace process," emphasis on *the*, a term used reflexively to refer to Washington's stand whatever it may be (often efforts to undermine diplomacy), a practice that has been particularly instructive with regard to the Middle East and Central America.*

We return to the crucial documents that laid out the diplomatic options as the U.S./U.K. decided to bomb in accord with the dictates of the "new internationalism"—the Rambouillet Agreement

and the Serb National Assembly Resolution—merely noting here that both were kept under wraps, unavailable to the general population, though some of the crucial facts were released after the Peace Accord rendered them irrelevant to the threat of democracy, and it was even discovered that the Rambouillet ultimatum was "fatally flawed" and had undermined a course of diplomacy that "might have won the day" without the terrible human consequences of "brute force," all matters to which we return.

The bombing was undertaken five days after the withdrawal of the monitors with the rational expectation that "the result" would be atrocities and ethnic cleansing, and a "sudden, massive" flight and expulsion of Albanians. That indeed happened, even if the scale may have come as a surprise to some, though the Commanding General apparently expected nothing less.